



YASBANT NEGI

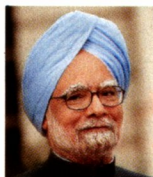
KEY Referees



SONIA GANDHI

Member, NMML Society

Quit the Executive Council after the office-for-profit controversy. Is behind the Rs 20-crore grant from the PMO to the NMML for modernisation. Briefed Mukherjee herself on what she expects. Has the final veto on whether certain sensitive papers can be made available to certain scholars.



MANMOHAN SINGH

President, NMML Society

Heads the Ministry of Culture. Is the recipient of several letters criticising and supporting Mukherjee. In 2005, when Jaipal Reddy offered to make him director, Guha had sent Manmohan a note saying the position should be filled by a transparent process. Is expected to toe Sonia Gandhi's line.



KARAN SINGH

Vice-Chairman, NMML Executive Council

Is unhappy with the massive intellectual lobbying on both sides. Says his shoulders are broad enough for the responsibility of choosing whether or not the current director should get an extension. Wants due process to be followed in future. Wants the NMML Society to meet.

responsible for the 1984 Sikh riots in his book *India After Gandhi*. By implication, he was anti-Congress.

The letters defending Mukherjee also allege that the timing of the protest led by Guha is suspiciously close to the strictures by the Parliamentary Petitions Committee, which pulled up the panel that selected the fellows in 2006, accepting applications past the due date. Guha was a member of the panel, as were Neera Chandoke and Arjun Sengupta. On this, Guha says it is standard practice in all academic selections. The strictures have now resulted in the suspension of deputy director N. Balakrishnan, an NMML veteran of 25 years, even though he was not mentioned in that report.

Even as the circus shows no signs of slowing down, the real issues are likely to remain buried. NMML is under the Ministry of Culture and is run on public money, with an annual budget of around Rs 11 crore. Yet the taxpayer has virtually no say in its administration. Mukherjee was appointed without following the set procedure, which requires that a search committee be formed. For nine years between

1997—when Ravinder Kumar retired after 17 excellent years in which he set up the highly regarded Centre for Contemporary Studies—and 2006, the NMML was run by bureaucrats. Even now, the executive council has no representation from the academic community. The NMML Society has not met for over five years. And many of its activities, whether it is renting out its auditorium for Youth Congress meetings or starting a children's centre, are divorced from its daily life as a research institution.

Perhaps it is the curse of all great public institutions in India, trying to be everything to everyone. Or perhaps it's just that the director could not communicate her missionary zeal to transform the institution to enough members of the academic community. The NMML is, after all, a strange beast, combining a museum, an archive, a library and a planetarium (for which Mukherjee has asked for a further Rs 10-20 crore for modernisation, promised to her under the Commonwealth Games Fund).

Perhaps the time has come to

streamline the NMML, keeping its academic function, of generating intellectual diversity separate from its populist goal, more suited to Bal Bhavan and Sahmat. Gone are the NMML seminars in the past that gave rise to papers and books of enduring quality such as Aijaz Ahmad's *In Theory* on post-colonial literature and Sumit Sarkar's classic work *Writing Social History*. In place are empty spectacles such as lectures by Martin Luther King III or even the president of the regional council of Reunion Island.

Added to it is the crucial question of access. All collections that have any bearing on foreign policy, Kashmir or China, are now closed till the director gives permission. One major collection that Guha mined extensively for his book were the P.N. Haksar papers, key files in which have now been denied to at least five scholars subsequently for fear of offending the Gandhis. Is any openness possible when an institution is on the fuzzy borderlines between the government the party, between the party and the enduring First Family? It may be time to save Nehru from the Gandhis. ■